

that a senior Union officer had misidentified as friendly. This problem stemmed from the confusing variety of clothing worn by early Civil War regiments, before blue and gray became standard uniform colors. The Union infantry supports had also performed poorly.

The Confederate capture of the two Union batteries on Henry Hill became the turning point of the battle, and one last Federal attempt to turn the Confederates at Chinn Ridge, west of Henry Hill, failed.

When Confederate forces counter-attacked at the ridge, strengthened by two brigades newly arrived from the Shenandoah Valley, the Federals panicked and retreated in disarray. They were joined in their retreat by fleeing Union civilians from Washington—spectators who had attended the battle expecting it to be an outdoor stage where treason would be justly chastised.

While the Northern volunteers had in many ways fought well, their lack of experience and discipline showed. However, chaos also reigned among the victorious Confederates—likewise a product of their inexperience—and this would allow Union troops to return to the safety of the fortifications surrounding Washington, despite the frantic disorder accompanying their retreat.

The battle served as a fitting herald for the start of the war, and Confederate President Jefferson Davis himself traveled to the site before the combat ended. He afterward wrote the telegram reporting the victory to the Confederate War Department in Richmond. The Confederacy had survived, and the battle would ensure that the new nation would not be crushed in one demoralizing blow at the beginning of the war.